



Paws and PCS Orders

The Great British Pet Adventure

Receiving Permanent Change of Station (PCS) orders to the United Kingdom is an exciting milestone, but for military families moving with pets, it also marks the beginning of a high-stakes logistical countdown. The UK is a rabies-free island with incredibly strict border controls, meaning that standard international pet travel rules do not apply. Most notably, pets are completely barred from flying in the cabin on direct flights into the country, requiring alternative arrangements.

Remember that you cannot simply book a standard commercial ticket for your pet to fly next to you on a direct flight to London, you must choose between three distinct routes. Each path balances cost, convenience, and animal comfort differently. To help you execute a seamless transition for your dog and cat, this guide breaks down your primary transportation pathways, the non-negotiable health timelines, and the concrete steps needed to secure your bookings.

VACCINATIONS & TRAVEL DOCUMENTS

The UK government will mandate a costly quarantine at your expense if your veterinary paperwork contains even a minor error. To avoid this, you must complete the health requirements in an exact, non-negotiable chronological order:

1. **The ISO Microchip (Step One):** Your dog and cat must be implanted with a 15-digit ISO-compliant microchip. *The microchip must be implanted and read before or on the exact same day as the rabies vaccine.* If the rabies vaccine predates the microchip administration date on the paperwork, the vaccine is legally invalid for UK entry.
2. **The Rabies Vaccination:** Administer a 1-year or 3-year rabies vaccine after the microchip is active. You must wait a minimum of *21 full days* after the primary vaccination before your pet is legally permitted to enter Great Britain.
3. **Pet Health Certificate:** Within *10 days of your arrival at the UK border*, a USDA-accredited veterinarian must complete the official Pet Health Certificate. This document must then be submitted to and officially endorsed by the USDA.
4. **Tapeworm Treatment (Dogs Only):** Between *24 hours and 120 hours (1 to 5 days)* before your dog's scheduled arrival time in the UK, a veterinarian must administer an approved tapeworm treatment and record it precisely on the health certificate. Cats are exempt from this specific requirement.

Always keep the original proof of all required vaccinations in your carry-on luggage. It is highly recommended to print at least two physical backup copies, as both the airline staff at check-in and the border authorities upon arrival may need to inspect or retain them.

The Air Waybill (AWB): If your pets are flying via manifest cargo, the airline or your pet shipper will issue this critical document, which acts as the pet's flight ticket and freight tracking contract.

Owner Declaration & Authorization Forms: If you are utilizing a pet shipping agent or a friend to drop off the animals, you will need a signed non-commercial declaration form and a written authorization letter giving them legal permission to transport your pets.

UNDERSTANDING YOUR THREE TRANSPORTATION PATHWAYS

1. Manifest Cargo (The Direct Route)

The most direct method is flying your pets as manifest cargo on an approved commercial airline. Currently, major carriers operate pet-eligible routes into approved UK hubs, primarily London Heathrow (LHR).

This route means that your pets travel in the cargo hold. Upon arrival, they are transferred directly to the Heathrow Animal Reception Centre (HARC) for customs clearance. You are then REQUIRED to hire a registered UK pet broker or clearing agent to handle the customs entry paperwork.

2. The "France Loophole" (The In-Cabin Alternative)

If you have a cat or a smaller dog and want to avoid the cargo hold entirely, the "France Loophole" is an incredibly popular alternative among military families.

You book travel on an approved European airline (such as KLM, Air France, or Lufthansa) that allows pets inside the cabin from the US to an initial European destination like Paris or Amsterdam. Contact TMO to amend your PCS order to align with your alternative route.

Once you land in mainland Europe, you rent a pet-friendly vehicle or hire a taxi service to cross the English Channel into the UK via the Eurotunnel (Le Shuttle) or an approved pet-friendly ferry route. This avoids the UK's strict aircraft-cabin ban entirely.

3. Professional Pet Shippers (The Hands-Off Option)

If navigating foreign customs and airline regulations feels overwhelming, you can contract a dedicated third-party military pet relocation service.

These specialized companies manage the entire process, including ground transportation, veterinary documentation reviews, flight bookings, and broker clearance.

While this offers maximum peace of mind, it is the most expensive route, with international pet transport often ranging from \$3,000 to \$8,000 depending on the size and number of animals.

PET TRAVEL RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Manifest Cargo (The Direct Route) Recommendations

When shipping your pet directly across the Atlantic, they must travel safely in the cargo hold under official UK entry protocols. These trusted major airlines maintain designated live animal programs and operate direct routes into approved hubs like the [Heathrow Animal Reception Centre \(HARC\)](#).

- [British Airways IAG Cargo](#): Partners directly with pet shipping specialists to manage secure climate-controlled holding and transit into Heathrow.
- [American Airlines Cargo](#): Provides robust online air waybill tracking and maintains specific checked pet allowances for military personnel traveling on active PCS orders.
- Check out this website for more options:
<https://www.alternativeairlines.com/airlines-with-pet-cargo>

UK Customs Brokers & Clearance Agents

For pets arriving via manifest cargo, the UK government requires you to contract a registered customs broker to process the strict entry paperwork through the Border Control Post. These elite clearance teams work seamlessly with the [Heathrow Animal Reception Centre](#) and specialize in military Transfer of Residence (ToR) tax relief.

- [PBS Pet Travel](#): An authorized Heathrow agent widely recognized for handling complex military PCS customs clearance and logistics.
- [Animal Aircare](#): Operates dedicated facilities at both Heathrow and Gatwick, streamlining document verification and customs clearance tasks for inbound families.
- [Airsupply Pet Travel](#): Situated right at London Heathrow, they act as an affordable and highly efficient customs clearing agent for international military pet shipments.

2. The "France Loophole" (The In-Cabin Alternative) Recommendations

If you have a small dog or cat and prefer to skip the cargo hold, you can take advantage of the "France Loophole" by flying an airline that permits small carriers inside the main

cabin to mainland Europe. These options allow you to land in nearby hubs like Paris or Amsterdam before making your ground crossing.

- [Delta Air Lines](#): Widely preferred for small pets because they do not enforce a strict pet weight limit for the cabin, focusing instead on whether your pet can fit comfortably in a compliant under-seat carrier.
- [Air France](#): Allows small cats and dogs weighing up to 8 kg (including their carrier) to fly right under the seat in front of you on transatlantic routes.
- [KLM Royal Dutch Airlines](#): Offers excellent, highly rated in-cabin pet spaces directly from major US international hubs into Amsterdam Schiphol Airport.

Cross-Channel Pet Taxis & Ground Transportation

Once you touch down in France or the Netherlands, you will need to utilize the [Eurotunnel Le Shuttle](#) or a pet-friendly ferry route to legally enter the UK with your animal in the vehicle. These professional pet taxi services provide stress-free, private ground transportation directly to your new UK doorstep.

- [Le Pet Express](#): A highly recommended minibus shuttle designed specifically for travelers crossing the Eurotunnel with their pets without their own car.
- [Private Pet Taxi Paris to UK](#): Offers dedicated, family-run, door-to-door private vehicle transfers picking up directly from Paris CDG or Orly airports.
- [Elite Pet Taxi](#): Fully DEFRA-licensed and certified for long-distance European transit, specializing in VIP airport pickups from Amsterdam Schiphol to any destination in the UK.

3. Professional Pet Shippers (The Hands-Off Option) Recommendations

If you want to completely hand off the stress of flight bookings, veterinary timeline checks, compliant travel crates, and customs coordination, a full-service relocation agency is your best path. These top-rated companies provide end-to-end management tailored around strict military timelines and rotating base assignments.

- [Pets with Passports](#): A popular, women-owned agency frequently recommended in transatlantic relocation forums for handling complex international military moves and executing seamless entries into England.
- [TailWings Pet Travel](#): Based right at London Heathrow Airport, this boutique agency leverages over 30 years of airfreight experience to handle comprehensive

military PCS imports, customs paperwork, and Transfer of Residence (ToR) tax forms.

- [Island Pet Movers](#): A trusted, veteran-owned organization that specializes heavily in military PCS moves to UK bases, navigating Post-Brexit guidelines and base-specific registrations.
- [PetRelocation](#): A premiere global agency that orchestrates complete door-to-door moves, offering military-specific programs and expert oversight of the entire health documentation pipeline.